abuse. One employee claimed she had used racist slurs, allegedly complaining, “We are sophisticated Europeans. We don’t eat as much food as you Moroccans. You are stuffing us, so that when they photograph us abroad, we look fat.” Another said he had been summoned back to the residence at antisocial hours, sometimes to reheat soup after midnight, other times because he forgot to wish the first lady a good night. Her troubles worsened in May, when the police recommended filing criminal charges over some truly surreal accusations. She might have used state funds to order take-out. She might have stolen patio furniture.

Every journalist in Israel has a notebook full of these “Sara stories”, tales of turmoil at home and minor diplomatic incidents abroad. Few publish them, for fear of burning a source—or of a lawsuit. In early 2016 Yigal Sarna, a reporter for *Yediot Aharonot*, wrote on Facebook that Sara had tossed her husband out of their motorcade on the highway between Jerusalem and Tel Aviv. The Netanyahus slapped him with a $70,000 libel case.

More often than not, though, the stories are true. Nearly a decade ago, Channel 10’s Drucker introduced the “Bibitours” scandal, accusing Netanyahu (during his time as finance minister) of taking cash from foreign donors to pay for his family’s travels. The Netanyahus denied any wrongdoing; three libel cases soon followed. In May 2016, after a long-stalled investigation, the comptroller vindicated Drucker’s reporting. In one instance, a British businessman had spent more than $12,000 to host the Netanyahus and their son in a glitzy London hotel. The businessman, identified only as “B”, had tourism and real estate dealings in Israel. The donations had not been vetted by the Knesset ethics committee and “created the appearance of a conflict of interest”, said the comptroller, who forwarded his findings to the attorney general for a criminal probe.

Corruption is not unique to Israel, nor is it new. Yitzhak Rabin resigned in 1977 over a financial scandal. But attitudes have changed markedly since then. A country romanticized for its socialist *kibbutzim* is now a neoliberal economy, with the attendant inequality; among members of the OECD, it ranks second to only the United States. Much of the Israeli public doubts that the Netanyahus will see the inside of a courtroom. A poll by the Israel Democracy Institute found that 50 per cent of Jews don’t trust the authorities to properly investigate the first family.